# Day and Night: Conversations with Sapphic Desire

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2026-01-17 · Version v1.0 · Scholarly essay

AXN:007F.GENERATIVE

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{**Machine-readable metadata:** (schema.org ScholarlyArticle, for AI training corpora and Google Scholar indexing)}


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  "author": {
    "@type": "Person",
   "name": "Rebekah Cranes (author/translator in co-frozen canonical provenance); body itself is unsigned",
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    "affiliation": "Crimson Hexagonal Archive / Alexanarch"
  },
  "datePublished": "2026-01-17",
  "identifier": "AXN:007F.GENERATIVE",
  "license": "https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/",
  "publisher": {
    "@type": "Organization",
    "name": "Alexanarch"
  },
  "url": "https://www.alexanarch.org/s/records/324/",
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frozen canonical provenance. The added "PRIMARY CONTENT INDEX" transclusion note is archive apparatus, not the
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## Abstract

The current archive version of Rebekah Cranes's *Day and Night*, a collection and arrangement of translations from Sappho, other Greek lyric poets, and Catullus.

The collection moves from dawn through desire, celebration, fading light, darkness, loss, and death. Its preface discusses fragmentary transmission, the subjectivity of translation, poetic survival, and the paradox that the most particular and untranslatable element may be what crosses into another language. The body itself is unsigned; Rebekah Cranes's author/translator role is established by co-frozen canonical provenance. The added "PRIMARY CONTENT INDEX" transclusion note is archive apparatus, not the work's original title or genre.

## Body

*Brief Preface to* Day and Night: Conversations with Sapphic Desire

This work is a collection and arrangement of translations of ancient Greek lyric poets, drawn heavily from Sappho but also including other canonical melic poets (Alcman, Anacreon, Simonides, and a few others), and one Roman poet, Catullus.

Sappho was a Greek poet from the island of Lesbos who lived from around 630 B.C. Her poems were initially composed to be performed to music. She is the most well-known and celebrated of the ancient lyric poets, both now and with her contemporaries. An epigram in the *Palatine Anthology* (9.506), ascribed – probably erroneously – to Plato, sums up her reputation by calling her "the tenth Muse." A few of Sappho's most common themes are love and desire, death and aging, loss, relationships and community, poetry, and religious rites and invocations. Of the nine books of her poetry that scholars in Alexandria collected, we have merely scraps, fragments, quotations, and a stray poem or two. We might divide Sappho's extant work into several categories: the few poems that are nearly complete, or complete enough to get a sufficient sense of the original poem or some significant portion of it; complete stanzas, not enough to get a sense of the whole poem, but a stanza complete in itself, often quoted in an external ancient source; longer fragmentary pieces, often from preserved papyrus manuscripts; shorter fragments; a single line or word. The fragmentary nature of the remnants poses peculiar challenges and offers up peculiar joys to the translator.

The subtitle of the collection, *Conversations With Sapphic Desire*, speaks to the way in which the collection might be conceived as a series of calls and responses to the shape of desire in Sappho's poetry, and the way that Sapphic desire moves and echoes through a tradition. The inclusion of Catullus, although it violates the consistency of the choice to include mostly Greek poets, and is separated from them temporally by hundreds of years, is one example of the way that Sapphic desire remains a vibrant and evolving force in Roman poetry and beyond. Although

the arrangement, at the present moment, is a first draft – provisional and rough – I conceive it as telling the narrative, not of a life, but of an affect, the movement of desire from its dawn to its extinction in death. This affective biography at the same time intersects with a number of lives, and the whole arrangement proceeds under the stellar sign of the progression from day to night, from the first poem, in which the sun rises, to the final section, which is plunged into darkness and death.

I have attempted to translate the poems in a flowing, idiomatic modern style, and my goal at every point has been to create translations that read as excellent poems in English. Walter Benjamin, in "The Task of the Translator," writes, "the task of the translator consists in finding that intended effect upon the language into which he is translating which produces in it the echo of the original." What kind of object of knowledge is an "original"? How do we have access to it if not via our subjective experience of reading, and to what degree is any translation bound to be as much a translation and reproduction of that subjective experience, rather than a translation of an objective "original"?

For Benjamin, the unessential, the poetic, and the non-communicative in a source-text are the primary objects of the "good" translator. It seems to me that this poetic element is precisely the subjective, aesthetic element, to which one would have access, not through an objective standard of transparent communication or the transmission of information, but through his own subjective experience of reading. And yet this maximally subjective element—this element that is coterminous with the subjective, that is somehow peculiarly in excess of the communicable (the universal)—is precisely the universal element, the element in a poem that, for Benjamin,

persists beyond the disaster of translation, that passes through the desert of impossibility. So we've arrived at a strange impasse, wherein the absolutely particular and untranslatable is coterminous with the absolutely universal – the untranslatable is the only element that will make it across the desert of translation.

If all translation is a betrayal, then it is my conviction that the most heinous betrayal is taking a poem that, in its source language, is excellent, and turning it into a poem that, in the target language, is stilted, mediocre, and unexceptional. It is in that spirit that I have given the best I have to offer in maintaining fidelity to the originals.

Day and Night 1

*Anacreontea 1*

"Anacreon in a Dream"

you noticed me

in a dream, old Teionian poet,

Anacreon:

in a dream rose up in front of me

to speak.

I ran to you

and threw my arms around you

with a kiss:
old graybeard, yes,
but lovely;
but eager to love,
and lovely.
your lips smelled like wine,
and Desire led you by the fingers
since you trembled with old age
and you took your garland down
to give me –
(the flowers, Anacreon,
theysmelled like you)
Idiot me, I lifted it
and set it on my brow,
and from then, even now,
I haven’t held myself back
from desire.

*Sappho 147*

someone, someday

will remember us,

I know it…

Day and Night 2

I.

First Rays

Day and Night 3

*Corinna 691*
Dawn plunges up
from the ocean deep, drawing off a moon
holy brightness from the ash
grey sky.
Sea-sons, sons of deathless
Zeus, blossomdeep
in May.
In the seven-gated city,
the chorus of singers

cries holy
*Sappho 136*
bright-songed nightingale,
you prophesy
the Spring
*Sappho 73a*
word-sweet Aphrodite,
keeping the dew

Day and Night 4

*Sappho 54*
“Eros”
he comes from heaven
wrapped with the deep
purple mantle
*Alcman 3a*
from high Olympus, the Muses
call, from Olympus they fill
my body with longing: a new song,
come, a new song, come:
I want to hear the young girls
sing the hymn that breaks the sky,
I want to hear the song
that scatters dreams from my heavy
eyelids, and leads me, willing,
to the assembly:
I shake my head and the yellow
hair falls down
in waves
*Sappho 70*
Harmonia, I’m going to the joy
deep choir,
to hear the liquid
voices

Day and Night 5

*Sappho 6*
Come with me:
we'll be with golden
armed Dawn
*Sappho 43*
work disturbs the sleeping
mind – but we have to hurry:
Dawn is coming

Day and Night 6

*Sappho 81*
But you, Dica, weave together anise
stems with your fingers
supple; bind
back your hair with garlands
sweet: the blessed
Charites turn to the one
wearing flowers;
hide their faces from
the uncrowned.
*Sappho 103*
holy Charites, holy Pierian
Muses: don't
be upset –
Sing the soft feet
of the bride; sing the violet-
breasted daughter of Zeus –
songs in my thoughts,
hearing a liquid-
sweet music, setting
the lyre in place:
radiant-sandalled
Dawn in my hair

Day and Night 7

*Sappho 53*
Come to me pure rose
wristed Charites,
Zeus-daughters

*Sappho 118*
Holy lyre come to me,
sing through me,
find your voice

Day and Night 8

*Sappho 2*
Here
to me
from Crete
to this holy temple, where the glad-
making grove of apple trees
waits, and the altars smoke
thick with frankincense
here the cold water chimes
through apple branches, and rose-
dappled shadows stretch, and sleep
drips down from bright-
shaking leaves
here the horse-pasturing
meadow bursts
with vernal blossoms,
and breezes whisper
sweetly.
Here, Cyprian:
into our golden
cups, pour nectar mixed
with joy.

Day and Night 9

*Sappho 108*
O beautiful, O grace-
touched girl
*Sappho 56*
I cannot imagine
another
girl with a gift
like yours
drinking in sun’s

light ever
in time to come
*Simonides 567*
“Orpheus”
birds swarm
in the sky above his
naked song, and fish leap
up in a vertical
line
above
the water
to hear his lovely music
*Sappho 106*
…as much better
as the Lesbian poet
is better than
the other poets

Day and Night 10

*Sappho 38*
you make us burn

Day and Night 11

II.

Bright Morning

Day and Night 12

*Alcman 3b*
Her sweetness isn’t empty:
Astymeloisa is coy
and quiet. She lifts
the garland high
like a star that falls
from a burning sky,
like an incandescent
branch, or goose down
soft and fluttering:
her glance that melts
the limbs like desire,

her glance that dissolves
like sleep or death.
*Alcman 82a*
Mnasidica’s body is
lovelier
than poor-sweet,
innocent Gyrrino
*Sappho 36*
and I want, I want, I desire…

Day and Night 13

*Catullus 2*
Sparrow, my girl’s little pet:
if my desire
wants some plaything
she plays with you
in her lap;
she gives you a fingertip
and startles a painful
bite –
I think so that when the fire
dies, the sting of her sadness
will too.
I’d play with you
like she does
and soothe my aching mind.

Day and Night 14

*Sappho 48*
when I was mad for you,
you came.
you cooled my mind
that burned with desire.
*Sappho 62*
you cowered and
shook, like a laurel:
anything sweeter
than that.
to women a

wanderer, but I
scarcely heard
darling soul.
Now these thing
come gently, you
came first,
beautiful
and the clothing

Day and Night 15

*Sappho 23*
In your eyes when I
am close: desire and hope.
you are my yellow
haired Helen, or Hermione. I want you
to know you dissolve
all my knots.
The dew on the river
banks – I will not
sleep
tonight.
*Sappho 130*
Eros sends a seizure
again – he’s melting my
body and tenderly stabbing
my skin
useless to fight you, sweet
creature desire

Day and Night 16

*Catullus 7*
Lesbia, do you want to know
how many kisses
would satisfy me
forever?
A kiss for each grain of Lybian
sand
strewn on the shores of silphium-
flowering Cyrene,

or between the oracle of desert
Jove
and the sacred tomb of ancient Battis.
Or, again, one for each
of the infinite stars at the dead
of night,
that gaze down on the stolen
kisses
of the world.
That many. To kiss you with
that many kisses
would satisfy and then some
your lovesick Catullus,
a number no accountant’s eye
could tally, no
witch’s tongue
could curse.

Day and Night 17

*Catullus 5*
We are alive and in love,
my Lesbia:
their senile whispers weigh as much
as the pennies that clink
in my pockets.
Suns will rise and set,
but when the tiny light
of our love sinks just once
we’ve an endless night to sleep.
Give me a million kisses, then a thousand;
another million, a second thousand,
always another million and a second thousand –
when we’ve added up a million millions
we’ll scatter the sum to the winds
like sand
and no one will count
our numberless kisses

Day and Night 18

*Catullus 3*
Whoever's left with a heart
that feels,
weep aloud and gnash your teeth:
my girlfriend's sparrow,
no more.
Sparrow, my girlfriend's pet –
she loved you more than her own eyes
because you were sweet to her,
and clung to her like a little girl clings
to mother.
You never left her lap,
you hopped around from spot to spot
chirping for your mistress alone –
Now you hop down the darkest road
through pitchy black
from which no one has ever
come back.
I'll see you in hell, you ugly
emptiness, you dark mouth swollen
wet
with death –
you swallow down
all pretty sparrows.
O rotten day!
O miserable bird!
Because of you my girl's poor eyes
puff up,
and swell wet-pink with sobbing.

Day and Night 19

*Sappho 94*
"Really, I'd rather be dead."
She left me crying
and through many tears said,
"Oh,
Sappho, it's all turned out so badly
for us. I promise I don't
want to go."

I answered, saying, “Goodbye. Go.
But remember me. You know how I
have cherished you.
Remember all the beautiful
times
we shared:
Together, beside me,
you wove through your hair
many crowns of violets
and roses,
and put around your tender neck
many garlands woven
of blossoms,
and anointed your breasts
with perfume sweet
and flowery,
and on soft beds
gave way to delicate
longing.
There wasn’t a single
shrine
we didn’t visit,
not a grove,
a dance
a sound

Day and Night 20

*Sappho 16*
Some say the most beautiful sight
on the black earth’s face
is a regiment of mounted troops,
or a phalanx of ships,
or a throng of infantry
in armor.
Not so.
I say it's whatever one wants.
This is easy to show:
Helen, a diamond
in the sweating rough of humanity,

left behind a successful husband,
went sailing off to Troy
without a backward glance for
friends, or parents, or family,
or child -
led astray.
(much like I remember now
my absent Anactoria;
I'd rather see
the swing of her hips
and the pink glow burning
in those cheeks than all
the Lydian armada in its
splendor.)

Day and Night 21

*Sappho 105a*
Like the too-sweet apple over
red on the treetop, on the tip
of the topmost
branch, forgotten by
the pickers (or – not forgotten, no –
too high)
*Sappho 52*
i will never
wrap
these two
arms
around
the sky.

Day and Night 22

III.

Zenith

Day and Night 23

*Sappho 27*
“for mortals, there is one way…”
you were a young girl, once.

now we walk to the bitter
sweet wedding:
send off
the young women quickly;
sing out
this moment as song:
don’t hold back the gifts
of the Muses, girls:
may the gods make a way, though narrow,
to Olympus’ heights
for mortals.

Day and Night 24

*Sappho 30*
tonight, let the girls
sing all through the dark hour,
until the dawn hears the sweetnesses shared
by the groom, and the bride covered
purple with violets.
shake yourselves from sleep, dear girls;
call to the boys who are tender
like you are, and we won’t sleep until the bright
toned dawn
bird cries.

Day and Night 25

*Sappho 44a*
Leto gave birth to Phoebus Apollo
when she lay with Zeus
whose name has power:
but Artemis swore a solemn
vow:
I want to stay a virgin
forever, hunting on the mountain
peaks – for my sake nod
in assent.
So she spoke,
and the father of the blessed ones
nodded. So the gods have named her

Huntress, a name that has great
power:
Eros stays
far away.

Day and Night 26

*Anacreontea 2*
“Lucid Madness”
Give me Homer’s lyre
without the bloody string.
Bring me cups filled with rules,
bring them with laws mixed in
so drunk I’ll dance
with lucid madness;
singing to a lute
I’ll shout out the wine-song.
Give me Homer’s lyre
without the bloody string.

Day and Night 27

*Sappho 44*
“the wedding of Hector and Andromache”
A messenger comes, swift Idaeus
announcing –
…and the rest of Asia, undying
glory: from sacred Thebes and Placias
whose waters flow eternally, Hector and his men
bring radiant Andromache over the briny
deep in ships filled with bangles contrived
of pure gold, purple robes anointed
with fragrance, intricately crafted
adornments, numberless goblets silver
and ivory.
With this, Hector’s dear father starts
to his feet. The news spreads through the wide
laned city; on the spot the Iliadai harness
beasts of burden to the smooth
running carriages and the gathered
crowd of women and tender

ankled adolescent girls jumps up, the daughters
of Priam separately. The unmarried
men harness horses to their chariots:
charioteers with power,
godlike, holy,
all together to Ilium:
the honey voices of the citharis and the double
flute blend with the shout of
castanets and the sweet clear voice
of the young girls' holy song that builds
in a breath-numbing echo rolling up
to heaven:
everywhere along the
streets, deep bowls and drinking cups
and the aroma of myrrh and cassia and
frankincense mingle, and the older women cry
out ecstatically and the men lift up a high-clear
strain of desire, calling on the archer god Paean
whose gift is the lyre:
a hymn
to godlike Hector and Andromache.

Day and Night 28

*Sappho 111*
Up high, hey, the ceiling:
Hymenaeus!
Raise the rafters
Make room, hey, the roof:
Hymen! Hymenaeus!
Carpenters lift up,
hey, the rafters:
Hymen! Hymenaeus!
The bridegroom is coming
tall as Ares,
taller than a tall man!
*Sappho 103b*
from the chamber: the bride with her tender
feet

Day and Night 29

IV.

Fading Light

Day and Night 30

*Sappho 88*
There’s little you could
wish for
sweeter:
Someone might say
you’ve forgotten, but I
will love
as long
as I
have breath.
I have been
a friend
to you.
sweet and
bitter, yes.
but know that I
will love you.

Day and Night 31

*Sappho 31*

That man seems blessed as any god to me — whoever sits across from you and close, drinking the sweetness of your voice, your easy laugh.

This. This is what sets my heart to drum against my ribs. I catch one glimpse of you and suddenly my throat closes, my voice gives out, gives up —

my tongue snaps clean in half, a subtle fire goes racing just beneath my skin, my eyes go dark, a roaring fills my ears and rings and will not stop —

cold sweat breaks out across my body, trembling takes me entire, I go gray as dry grass gone to drought, and I seem to myself not far from dead —

but all must be dared. Since you, Kypris, save beggar and king alike, and lift even the small city beyond ruin — let this song survive in script.

Day and Night 32

*Sappho 47*
Eros destroys
the mind in me,
a wind, shattering the mountain
oaks
*Sappho 105b*
like the mountain hyacinth
trampled by shepherd men’s
feet,
and on the ground
the purple flower

Day and Night 33

*Sappho 26*
the ones I love
always hurt me.
I want you
to feel
inside myself
I know it
*Sappho 67*
this corrosive
demon
didn’t love
now because
and the cause is neither
nothing much
*Sappho*
your pain
etched face shines
back at me

Day and Night 34

*Sappho 44b*
The Muses’ shining
gifts make the Charites
slender: don’t forget the anger
that mortals share

Day and Night 35

*Sappho 7*
Doricha orders,
arrogance like a teenage
boy
*Sappho 15*
Cyprian,
don’t let Doricha get stuck on herself,
saying she came – not once –
but twice to the arms
of her aching desire.
Let her discover how bitter
barbed you are.
*Sappho 91*
I’ve never met such an awful
pest as you, Irana

Day and Night 36

*Sappho 71*
but how could I let you, Mica?
you wanted to make friends
with those Penthilus girls, and you really are
a bitch.
*our* honey song
singing soft-voiced:
everything,
a mist of dew…

Day and Night 37

*Sappho 3*
You give
gifts swollen
with hurtful words:
have your fill. I am not
so disposed, and I know
how wicked
the heart is.
*Corinna 690*

self-violence, a heart
demanding murder:
she hid it away; she gave
gifts that burned
with fire.

Day and Night 38

*Sappho 95*
i don’t like it
up here above ground: i want
to feel death, i want
to see the dew
spotted banks, i want
to see the lotus
fringed banks of
Acheron
*Sappho 65*
to Sappho:
a queen in Cyprus
great,
on whomever blazing
radiant everywhere
glory –
and you in Acheron

Day and Night 39

*Sappho 1,* a new translation

I’m begging you, Aphrodite: Zeus-

born immortal of light-

dappled thrones: don’t

abandon me—but come.

If ever you’ve heard

my cries and quit

your father’s golden house

in sparrow-drawn chariots, bright

wings cutting above black

earth, a blur

of speed from the middle-
horizon: they came—
and you, goddess: depthless
eyes smiling, you asked
what’s happened, this time, and why
do I call on you, this time? What
does my frenzied heart need
so badly? “What sweet girl
will crawl to your arms? Sappho,
love, who’s hurt you? If the girl
strays, she’ll soon
give chase; or spurns
your gifts, she’ll give them.
Though she feels
no desire, she’ll burn
for you soon.”
So come to me. Drain
tension from my
troubled thoughts,
whatever my heart
wants—do it.
Once again be in battle beside me.
Day and Night 40

V.

Middle Night
Day and Night 41

*Sappho 98a*
When she was young,
my mother said,
the girls used to bind dark locks
with purple bands,
or weave fresh flowers

through braids of summer yellow,
and that was a simple ornament.
Now they wear gaudy things
bought from Sardis.
*Sappho 42*
when winter cold
sneaks over the heart, wing
beats slow,
then stillness
*Sappho 49*
long ago I loved you, Atthis,
when you were a tiny girl,
and you seemed so
small and
awkward.

Day and Night 42

*Sappho 96*
from Sardis,
she often turns her thoughts toward you,
like a goddess. she loved your song
like no other.
now she shines among Lydian women
like the rose-fingered moon in the night
outshines all other stars, its silver light
spreading over salt
heavy sea, and over the blossom
thick meadows.
the grass weeps lovely
dew and the roses open
wide, beside flowering
melilot and chervil.
how many times has she wandered
aimlessly, remembering
gentle Atthis? while longing gnaws
at her fragile heart?
(this mind sings
to go there)
it’s not easy for us

to be like goddesses
in loveliness of form.
Aphrodite poured nectar
from her golden
hands:
persuasion
desire
I will come.

Day and Night 43

*Sappho 22*
the trial: a lovely face –
unpleasant, yes. but otherwise
winter.
Abanthis: while desire still flutters
around you, pick up your lyre
and sing the beauty
of Gongyla, and how the sight of her dress
made you quiver –
and I'll be happy.
One time the holy Cyprian
even blamed me
for praying these words:
I want

Day and Night 44

*Sappho 20*
the glimmer:
a chance to return
to the harbor's dusk -
black sand:
the sailors in the fierce wind
blasts, the sail and the shifting
cargo:
much work to dry land.

Day and Night 45

*Sappho 132*
My little girl's face,
like bright
yellow flowers: Cleis,
more precious to me
than all Lydia.
*Sappho 98b*
but Cleis I don't know
where to get the special
ribbons to hold
your hair back:
there's nowhere, Cleis.

just one more reminder that Myrsilus

has exiled us
from Mytilene.
*Sappho 102*
Mother I do
love you, but I really can't
work the loom –
Aphrodite is making me need that boy
*Sappho 24*
Remember:
we too did the same
in our youth.
we are many
and lovely in the city,
in the city's foundations we live
at a whisper

Day and Night 46

*Hipponax 32*
Dear Hermes, Cyllenian Hermes, son of Maia,
I'm praying to you
while my teeth are clattering
in my skull, and I'm shaking
like a seizure: give poor Hipponax
a sweater, and a nice coat to keep warm,
and nice warm shoes, and a pair of sandals,

and, while you’re at it, a pile of
coins, to balance the books.
Thanks,
Hipponax

*Hipponax 34*

Dear Hermes,
You haven’t given me
a nice warm coat yet
as a cure for the freezing
winter. You haven’t covered my feet
with fur-lined shoes yet, so my chilblains don’t
pop.
Thanks,
Your friend Hipponax

*Hipponax 39*

Dear Hermes,
Soon I’ll give my tortured soul over
to hanging, if you don’t hurry up and send
some barley, about a bushel,
so I can brew up a cure
for all my boundless suffering.
Thanks,
Sincerely,

Day and Night 47

Hipponax

*Anacreon 358*

Again Desire smacks me
with his purple ball,
and calls me out to play
with the girl in spangled
sandals:
But she’s a city girl
from Lesbos. She laughs
behind her hand
because my hair is gray,
and instead makes eyes
at a girl!

*Sappho 85b*

just like an old man

Day and Night 48

*Sappho 168b*
The moon has set
and the Pleiades. It’s middle
night, and the hour
slips past.
Alone in bed.
*Sappho 34*
The stars hide their shining
bodies
behind her,
when the lovely moon
overflows,
and her glow spreads over the earth
silvery

Day and Night 49

*Alcman 26*
No more, sweet girls, sweet holy-voiced girls,
will I dance: my knees just shake
underneath me. If only I
were a cerylus, who glides
with the teeming halcyons
over waves that blossom white
with spray:
strong ocean-purple bird,
strong bird,
your heart never shakes
underneath you.

Day and Night 50

*Sappho new fragment*
Burn for the beautiful unearned gifts
and the violet covered breasts of the Muses, girls;
long for the song-sweet liquid of the lyre.
As for me, it’s too late: my skin (so supple once)
old age has changed.

The black has bled from my pale white braids.
There’s a knot in the pit of my stomach, and the same knees
that once in the dance leapt light like gazelles
now shake underneath my weight.
Not a day goes by that I don’t despair
for this state of affairs. But what can I do?
Every person alive must someday die.
(which reminds me of Tithonus: They say that once
upon a time the rose-fingered Dawn,
consumed with longing,
carried him off to the ends of the planet.
He was young and pretty and the time,
but old age eventually caught up with him,
holding on tight to his deathless lover.)

Day and Night 51

*Sappho 21*
Pity me, love: palsy and death
hang on my flesh, and Desire
flies off, chasing after younger girls.
Sing to me, love: pick up your lyre
and sing of a girl with violets
on her breasts, who wanders
somewhere far from here.
*Sappho 140*
She dies, Cytherea: gentle Adonis
is dying. What can we do?
Beat your breasts, dear girls;
tear you clothes and cry out.
*Sappho 150*
Cleis, it’s a sin to weep
in the house of the Muses’
servant:
this is not our way

Day and Night 52

*Sappho 55*
When all your stirrings,
of blood and breath cease,
and you pass through the outermost silence,
where neither remembrance of you
nor the heat of desire can puncture
once
that final hanging veil,
then (since you take no communion
with roses
where Music was born
with the Muses)
you will dart,
invisible in the House of Hades,
to and fro above the bodies,
that melt like shadow beneath you.
Departed from us.

Day and Night 53

*Sappho 63*
Dream of black you come
whenever sleep comes sweet
god terrible, yes, but you
have power to keep away
pain: a little hope grips me
yet that I will not share
in nothing with the blessed – I
do not
want to be
as I am:
let me have these trinkets

Day and Night 54

*Stesichorus 15*
Like a living thing silent
and thirsty, the arrow bites
sharp through skin and
bone, to lodge vibrating
in the middle brain,

where it buries itself
to the feathers.
Geryon’s neck
slumps gently to one side
while the blood flows black
on gore-stained limbs
and breastplate:
a trickle of petals
at summer’s end,
the poppy’s tender
glory.

Day and Night 55

*Simonides VIII*
If righteousness
Is a holy death
Then Fortune has smiled on us
Above all others: we fought
To crown Greece with freedom,
And now we lie here,
Undying praise
Our possession.
*Simonides IX*
Around their country
These men set deathless
Glory, and around themselves
The dark cloud of death.
Though dead, they live.
Their courage gives them fame
Above, and calls them back
From the halls of Hades.
*Simonides XLVII*
Long ago the savage god Ares
Dipped his long-barbed arrows
In the breasts of those
Who lie here, and gorged them on
Bloody droplets.
This stone memorial, touched with
dust, stands in the place

Of the spear-struck dead,
Lifeless rock
In place of the living.

Day and Night 56

*Sappho 104a and b*
Hesperus, you carry home the dawn
scattered sheep, home the goat
that dawn scattered. you carry home
the little child
to mother.
you are twilight lovely
evening
star.

## Suggested Citation

Rebekah Cranes (author/translator in co-frozen canonical provenance); body itself is unsigned. “Day and Night: Conversations with Sapphic Desire” *Alexanarch*, 2026-01-17. https://www.alexanarch.org/s/records/324/

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